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Peace, Love and Happiness (and Marketing)

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Brand Love's Greatest Hits

What's in the all time most-read research on brand love?

Updated July 6, 2023

Reviewed by Hara Estroff Marano



KEY POINTS

- Brand love is simply love, applied to possessions that have sentimental value or stir enthusiasm.
- Brand love, like other forms of love, uses many of the same psychological processes that create identity.
- The all-time most-read and -cited papers on brand love are listed and discussed.

Brand love is a pretty hot research area, with Google Scholar showing over 14,700 papers at least mentioning the topic.

That's a little more reading than most of us are up for. So, I've created a list of all the academic brand-love papers that have been cited more than 300 times each. Three hundred cita-



Source: Aaron Ahuvia

ence papers are never cited at all¹, and only 14 papers made the cut.

But before I talk about brand-love research's greatest hits, let me clarify what brand love is. Brand love is simply *love*, when

we love possessions that have sentimental value, a brand we're particularly enthusiastic about, or a product category we're very interested in, such as cars, restaurants, or fashion.

Here is the list of the most widely read and cited papers on brand love. I've also included a very brief description of some of the major findings from each study.

1. Carroll, B. & Ahuvia, A. C. *Some antecedents and outcomes of brand love* (2006). 3,268 citations. Includes the first brand-love scale. Brand love is greatest for brands that provide hedonic benefits and that are strongly linked to the consumer's identity. Brand love leads to brand loyalty and positive word of mouth.
2. Batra, R., Ahuvia, A. C. & Bagozzi, R. P. *Brand Love* (2012). 2,573 citations. Brand love is a complex psychological system that involves including the brand in the consumer's identity, passion-driven behaviors, positive emotional connection, a long-term relationship, a positive attitude towards the brand, and a belief that losing the brand would be emotionally painful. A very strong relationship was found between brand love and brand loyalty, word of mouth, and resistance to negative brand information.

tions. First major empirical work on non-interpersonal love. Consumers' love of possessions and brands is driven by consumers' integration of these items into their identity. Items are particularly strongly loved when they can reconcile consumers' felt identity conflicts.

4. Albert, N., Merunka, D. & Valette-Florence, P. *When consumers love their brands: Exploring the concept and its dimensions* (2008). 1,036 citations. Finds 11 aspects in respondents' feeling of brand love, including that love involves a strong congruity between the consumer's identity and the product image.
5. Albert, N. & Merunka, D. *The role of brand love in consumer-brand relationships* (2013). 1,012 citations. Brand love leads to brand commitment, positive word of mouth, and willingness to pay a price premium. Brand love comes from trust in the brand, perceived fit between oneself and the brand's image, and identification with other people who use the brand.
6. Bergkvist, L. & Bech-Larsen, T. *Two studies of consequences and actionable antecedents of brand love* (2010). 807 citations. Finds that the extent to which the brand has become part of the consumer's identity is an important cause of brand love. Feeling a sense of community with other users of the brand is also an important cause of brand love
7. Wallace, E., Buil, I. & Chernatony, L. de. *Consumer engagement with self-expressive brands: brand love and WOM outcomes* (2014). 709 citations. Consumers' tendency to "like" a brand on Facebook is driven by brand love. Brand love is driven both by the integration of the brand into the consumer's internal private self and integration into their public social self.

brands among young consumers (2012). 323 citations.

Love for fashion brands is explained mostly by the brand having a positive public image that consumers use in constructing their own identity. Brand love leads to positive word of mouth.

9. Albert, N., Merunka, D. & Valette-Florence, P. *Brand passion: Antecedents and consequences* (2013). 490 citations. This paper, *Brand Passion: Antecedents and Consequences*, is a conceptual replication of the authors' other 2013 paper, *The Role of Brand Love in Consumer-Brand Relationships*. However, this paper focuses specifically on the most passionate and emotionally intense aspects of brand love. It concludes that brand passion, like other aspects of brand love, arises from the brand "reflecting, participating in, or creating consumers' identity" (pg. 908). While brand passion leads to brand loyalty, word-of-mouth, and willingness to pay a price premium, these effects are weaker than they are in these authors' related paper, which uses a broader, less passion-focused, definition of brand love.
10. Huang, C. C. *The impacts of brand experiences on brand loyalty: mediators of brand love and trust* (2018). 470 citations. When a cell phone brand appeals to consumers' senses, this produces more brand love than when it stimulates thinking or bodily activity. Brand love leads to repeat purchase intentions, a willingness to pay higher prices, and a willingness to wait if the brand is out of stock.
11. Karjaluoto, H., Munnukka, J. & Kiuru, K. *Brand love and positive word of mouth: the moderating effects of experience and price* (2016). 350 citations. Brand love is driven by the ability of the brand to express the consumer's identity. Brand love leads to positive word of mouth both

priced brands.

12. Bagozzi, R. P., Batra, R. & Ahuvia, A. C. *Brand Love: development and validation of a practical scale* (2016). 331 citations. Presents a practical scale to measure brand love that overcomes some conceptual difficulties with the earlier Carroll and Ahuvia (2006) scale.
13. Rauschnabel, P. A. & Ahuvia, A. C. *You're So Lovable: Anthropomorphism and Brand Love* (2014). 318 citations. Anthropomorphism leads consumers to think about the brand as if it were a person, which leads to brand love. This is also connected to the link between brand love and identity. "Consumers love brands more when they see the brand not just as a person but also as a person like themselves."
14. Hsu, C. L. & Chen, M. C. *How gamification marketing activities motivate desirable consumer behaviors: Focusing on the role of brand love* (2018). 314 citations. Gamification of an online bookstore experience led to increased enjoyment and utilitarian value, which in turn led to increased brand love.

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bers 10 and 14). However, to say that the psychology of love is “linked to” the psychology of the self is something of an understatement. Rather, research shows that *the psychological processes through which we love are often the same mental processes through which we create our identity*.

Watanuki and Akama (2020)² conducted a meta-analysis of neuroscience studies comparing brain activation in people experiencing brand love to people experiencing interpersonal love. One of the main areas of neural commonality between these forms of love was that they both strongly activated brain regions used for processing information about the self. Watanuki and Akama concluded that “the core of brand love involves incorporating the loved object into the self” (p. 11).

If you’d like to learn more, my book on the psychology of brand love—*The Things We Love: How Our Passions Connect Us and Make Us Who We Are*—explains why the self plays such a prominent role in all forms of love.

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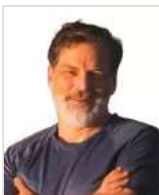
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